up against the bed, to throw darts. It came naturally to me, to repeat the action again and again, aiming to land the dart in the exact same spot, the noise of outside blocked out and hushed while I set myself a target to throw at. Eric Bristow – the rule-breaking star of darts in the 1980s – was another one of my heroes when I grew old enough to watch it on the telly and understand what was going on. There was something transformational about Bristow. He looked like all my parents' friends and almost every other adult male in Burnley – there was nothing about him that remotely resembled a high-level athlete. Watching him in the living room had the disorientating effect of feeling like he was sitting next to you, watching the darts too. And yet, when he stood in front of a dartboard, he transformed. The little finger of his right hand pointed out as he threw, a tiny sleight of hand that separated him from his opponents. He twiddled the dart. There is no other word for it. He twiddled it. The darts rotated and speared out of his hand, landing on the board with an energy and a fizz unimaginable to anyone he shared a board with. And then he was back again, drinking beer and smoking and watching the darts with everyone else.

And where each of these heroes had some sort of specified, designed relationship with their sport, Daley Thompson had decided he could do all of it. At the 1988 Olympics, participating in the decathlon, he was like an action figure from my wildest dreams. He was doing everything I was doing, just at a slightly higher level. He ran 100-metre sprints, he did hurdles, he jumped into sandpits, he jumped over impossibly high bars, he threw javelins and what appeared to be boulders and tiny little UFOs through the sky and into the distance. There was nothing he could not do, he was a natural at everything. Broad-shouldered, he was the definition of smouldering. He did not even need to say anything. He said it all when he competed.

I remember the commentary during his pole-vaulting heroics at the LA Olympics in 1984. It must have filtered into my system because I can recall the commentator saying, 'He hasn't been beaten since 1978, and when he did then, he cried for two days.' I would have been halfway through turning the living room into a pole vault arena when I heard it. It is quite hard to imagine Daley Thompson alone, crying for two days, but I somehow already knew his pain. His sacrifice was all there, in those shoulders, the way he had to stay tall at all times, as if one chink in the body armour and